



SUDAN

Capital city: Khartoum
Area: 967,493 sq miles (2,505,810 sq km)
Population: 33,600,000
Official language: Arabic
Major religions: Muslim 70%, traditional beliefs 20%, Christian 9%, other 1%
Government: Military government
Currency: Sudanese dinar
Adult literacy rate: 60%
Life expectancy: 58 years
People per doctor: 10,000
Televisions: 87 per 1,000 people

SUDAN

SUDAN, THE LARGEST COUNTRY in Africa, is one of the poorest and least developed countries in the world. The Nile River flows from south to north, and most people live along its fertile banks. The landscape ranges from rocky desert in the north to swampland in the south. Sudan is also divided culturally. The people of the north are mainly Arabic-speaking Muslims, while in the center and south, African languages and religions, together with Christianity, dominate. Clashes between the two sides have led to decades of civil war.

NOMADIC LIFE

Many of Sudan's tribal people live by herding cattle, moving from place to place in search of fresh pasture. The more cattle a person owns, the greater his importance in the tribe. The civil war has disrupted the lives of many herders, destroying their pastures and their herding routes.



The Dinka tribe are nomadic cattle herders who live on the plains east of the Nile.



WATERING THE LAND

Much of Sudan is too dry to live or farm in, and large areas of suitable farmland have been destroyed by war. The majority of people live by the Nile River and use its water to irrigate their fields. Two-thirds of workers make their living from the land, growing crops such as cotton, peanuts, gum arabic, millet, and dates. A large-scale irrigation program set up by the government has helped farmers to grow more crops for export.



Flat-roofed houses built of mud brick are common in northern Sudan.

TRIBES

The people of Sudan are divided into more than 500 different tribes and groups speaking more than 100 languages and dialects. Each tribe shares a common ancestor. Many, such as the Dinka and Juhaynah tribes, are nomadic. Others have settled in particular areas, such as the Shilluk tribe, a farming group living on the west bank of the Nile. The people shown left are from the Beni Amer tribe, a Muslim group.

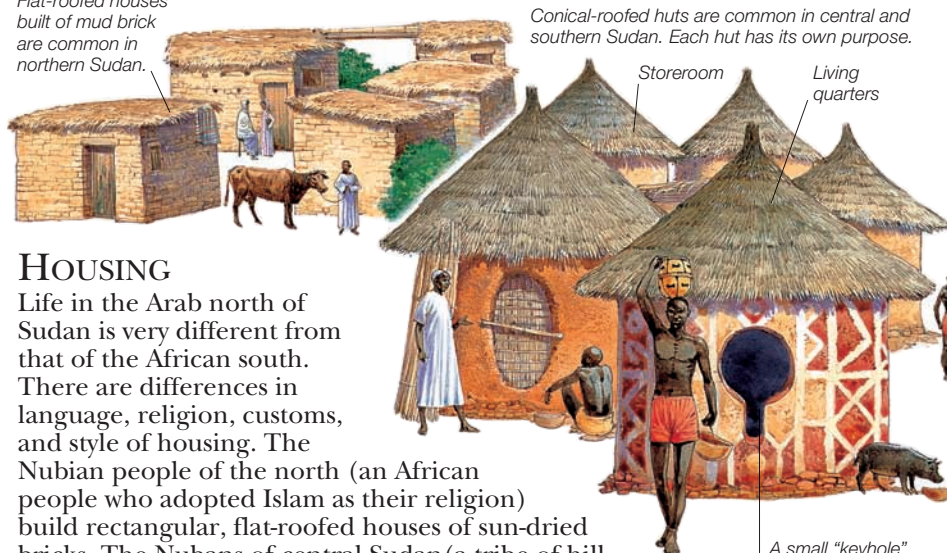


KHARTOUM

Since Sudan became independent in 1956, the Muslim government in the capital, Khartoum, has tried to impose Islam on the rest of the population, leading to civil war and famine. Millions of refugees have poured into Khartoum from the south and west to escape the fighting and to find food and work. Many now live in shantytowns on the outskirts of the city.

HOUSING

Life in the Arab north of Sudan is very different from that of the African south. There are differences in language, religion, customs, and style of housing. The Nubian people of the north (an African people who adopted Islam as their religion) build rectangular, flat-roofed houses of sun-dried bricks. The Nubans of central Sudan (a tribe of hill farmers) build round huts with conical roofs made of grass, wooden poles, and millet stalks.



Conical-roofed huts are common in central and southern Sudan. Each hut has its own purpose.

Storeroom Living quarters

A small "keyhole" doorway helps keep the hut warm and dry inside.

Wrestling is a popular sport among the Nuban people.

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